Advanced Rhythm and Coordination

Changing subdivisions, two against three, syncopation and compound pulse.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Keep a stable internal subdivision
2. Coordinate two against three
3. Maintain pulse through syncopation
4. Larger beats in compound time
5. Expressive timing with a shared pulse
6. Blessed Assurance: three large beats
7. Come Thou Fount: motion without rushing
8. Blessed Assurance: confident compound time

1. Keep a stable internal subdivision

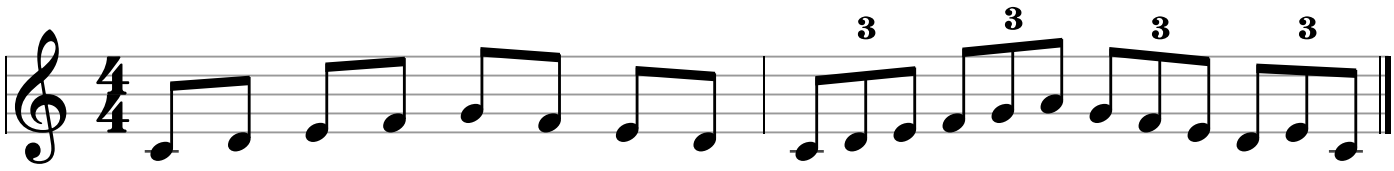
Move between quarters, eighths and triplets without changing pulse.

Keep a stable internal subdivision

Tap a steady quarter-note beat before playing. Fit two equal eighths into one tap, then three equal triplet eighths into the next. The beat does not speed up when there are more notes. Speak one-and for two and one-trip-let for three. Practise one change at a time, with no pedal, so the attacks remain clear.

Practise · Two then three

The first bar uses eighths; the second uses triplets over the same quarter pulse.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Triplets over a bass pulse

Let the left hand mark quarters while three right-hand notes fit into each beat.

Practise independently

Tap four quarters while saying the changing subdivisions. If your beat accelerates, lower the tempo and use one pitch until the switch feels steady.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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2. Coordinate two against three

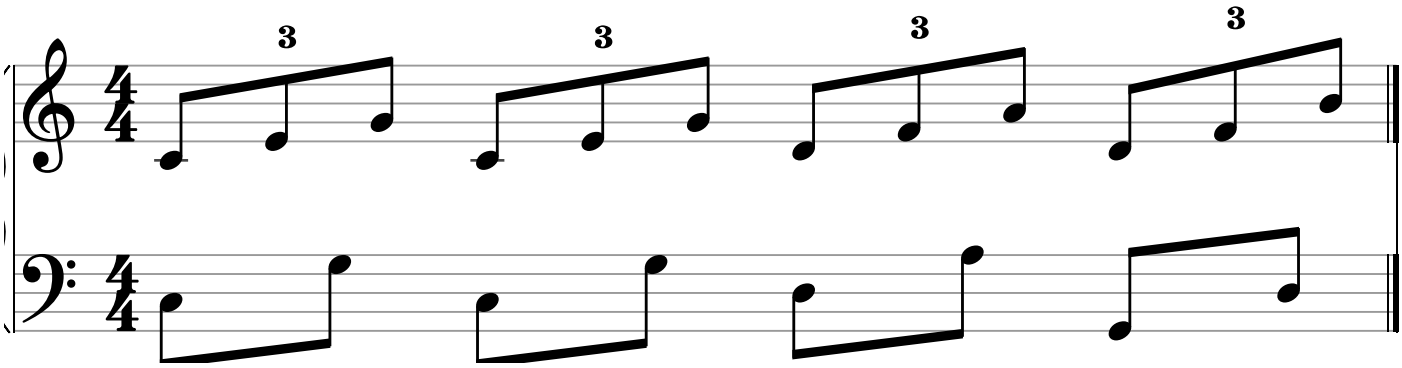
Place unequal divisions accurately within one shared beat.

Coordinate two against three

The hands meet at the start of each beat. Divide the beat into six small slots: the three-note hand plays slots 1, 3 and 5; the two-note hand plays slots 1 and 4. Clap this slowly before adding pitches. Do not swing the triplet or let the second left-hand note drag toward the last triplet. First practise a single beat, then repeat four beats.

Practise · Three right, two left

Use six silent subdivisions per beat. Both hands restart together on the next beat.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Reverse the roles

Now keep two right-hand eighths against three left-hand triplets.

Practise independently

Clap each role, then both together on your knees. Use Flow only after you can feel the shared beat. Return to separate hands if one pattern keeps changing to match the other.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

3. Maintain pulse through syncopation
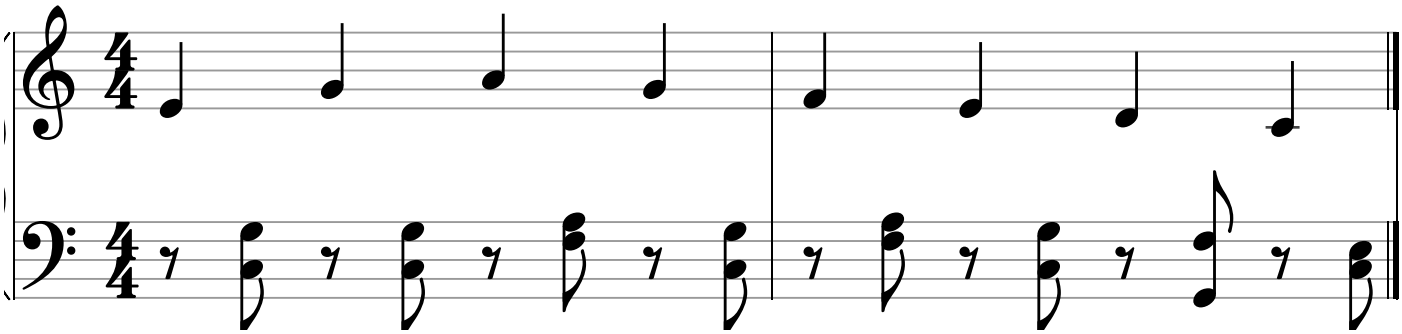
Hear the beat even when an accompaniment enters off it.

Maintain pulse through syncopation

A syncopated note may begin between beats and continue across a strong beat. Tap the pulse while speaking the rhythm. Learn the written rests as actively as the notes; an early entrance removes the syncopation. In hymn accompaniment use this texture selectively and keep the singer’s rhythm easy to follow.

Practise · Offbeat entries

Keep the melody on the beat while the left hand enters on each and.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Across the bar line

Hold the tied G through the next downbeat; do not strike it again.

Practise independently

Tap the beat with the accompaniment alone. Then restore the tune and check that the offbeat pattern supports rather than competes with the phrase.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

4. Larger beats in compound time
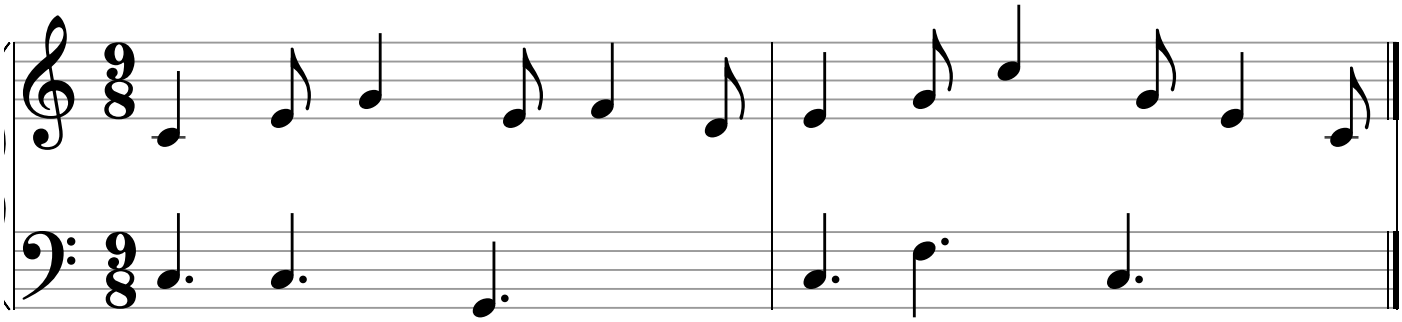
Keep three subdivisions inside each dotted-quarter pulse.

Larger beats in compound time

In 9/8 there are normally three large beats, each containing three eighths. In 6/8 there are normally two. Count the large beats and feel the smaller divisions inside them. The app tempo uses quarter-note units, so listen to the count-in rather than assuming its number is dotted-quarter beats per minute. Avoid accents on every eighth.

Practise · Three large beats

Count 1-and-a, 2-and-a, 3-and-a. Lean gently toward each phrase goal.



Opening example · 9/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Two large beats

Keep the bass changes at the two large pulses in each bar.

Practise independently

Conduct the large beats while listening to Blessed Assurance. Then play the melody alone, keeping pickups light and arriving on the first full large beat together.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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5. Expressive timing with a shared pulse
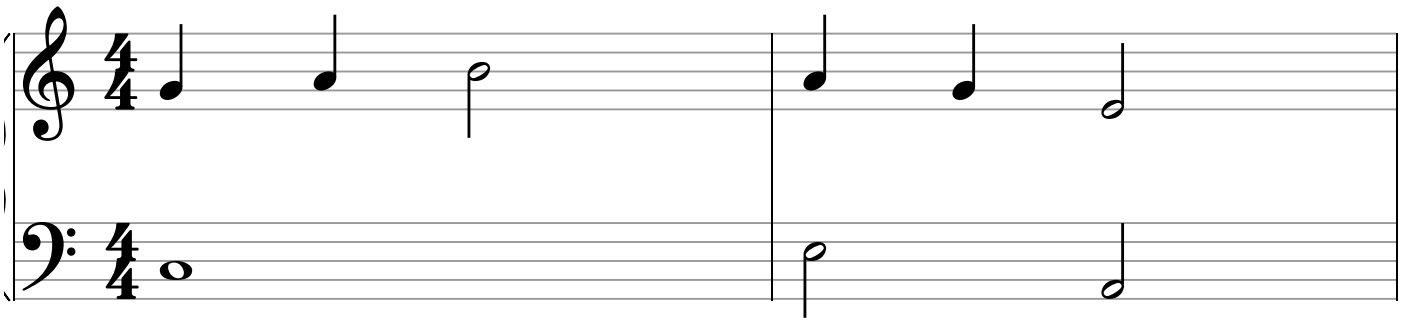
Distinguish solo rubato from timing that a singer can follow.

Expressive timing with a shared pulse

Solo rubato should clarify a phrase. Plan where the phrase moves forward and where it settles; avoid an unplanned delay at every difficult note. When accompanying a singer, agree on breaths and endings in advance and watch or listen for their lead. Practise the passage strictly first. Make the expressive version offline, because the reference timing check follows the written clock.

Practise · A stable reference

Play strictly first. Keep the same pulse through the cadence.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A singer’s breath

Count the rest fully. Prepare the next entry without a surprise early attack.

Practise independently

Perform the first phrase twice offline: once strictly and once with a planned broadening at the end. Ask whether the timing makes the sentence clearer and whether a singer could follow the entry.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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6. Blessed Assurance: three large beats

Feel three dotted-quarter pulses in 9/8, each containing three eighths. Keep the pickup light and the accompaniment even.

Prepare the score
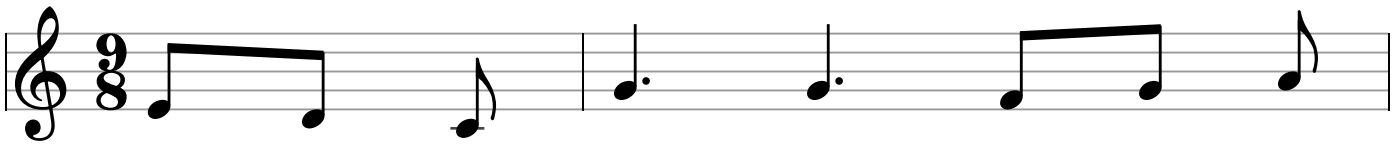
Feel three dotted-quarter pulses in 9/8, each containing three eighths. Keep the pickup light and the accompaniment even.

The left-hand pattern samples the retained source harmonies at each eighth note. It is an original piano accompaniment.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 9/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Feel three dotted-quarter pulses in 9/8, each containing three eighths. Keep the pickup light and the accompaniment even.

Practise · Blessed Assurance: three large beats

Feel three dotted-quarter pulses in 9/8, each containing three eighths. Keep the pickup light and the accompaniment even.

Make your own musical decision

Conduct the large beats while listening. Then play one phrase without the demonstration and check that dotted notes did not compress.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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7. Come Thou Fount: motion without rushing

Keep the three-quarter bar steady as the left hand moves in eighths. Listen for an even subdivision across every position change.

Prepare the score
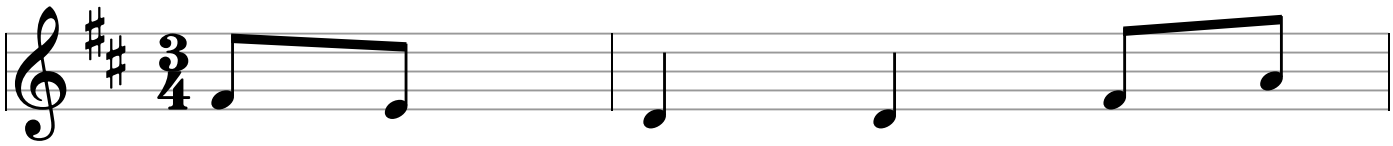
Keep the three-quarter bar steady as the left hand moves in eighths. Listen for an even subdivision across every position change.

The left-hand pattern samples the retained source harmonies at each eighth note. It is an original piano accompaniment.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 3/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Keep the three-quarter bar steady as the left hand moves in eighths. Listen for an even subdivision across every position change.

Practise · Come Thou Fount: motion without rushing

Keep the three-quarter bar steady as the left hand moves in eighths. Listen for an even subdivision across every position change.

Make your own musical decision

Practise one phrase strictly, then try a restrained planned broadening offline. Return to the strict reference for a Flow timing check.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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8. Blessed Assurance: confident compound time

Keep the large 9/8 pulse through the verse and refrain, with a clear melody above a soft, even moving accompaniment.

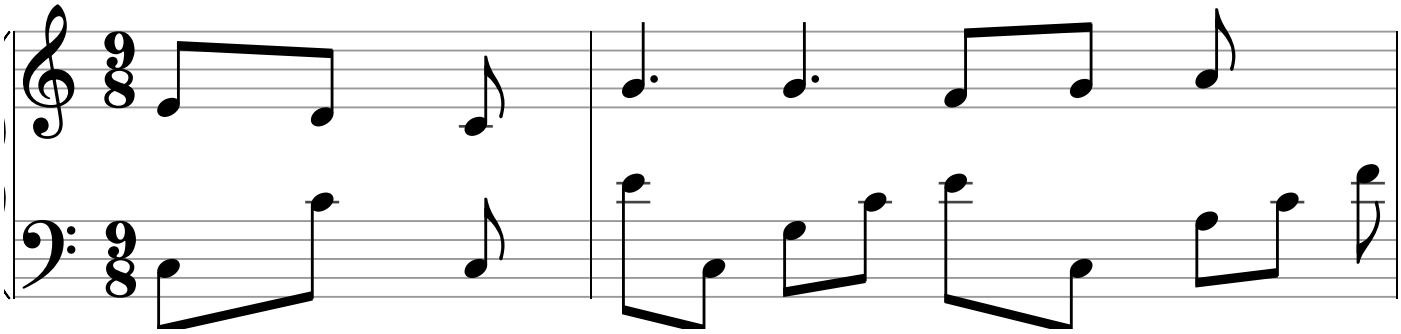
Prepare a complete performance

Keep the large 9/8 pulse through the verse and refrain, with a clear melody above a soft, even moving accompaniment.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Blessed Assurance

Keep the large 9/8 pulse through the verse and refrain, with a clear melody above a soft, even moving accompaniment.



Opening example · 9/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Keep the large 9/8 pulse through the verse and refrain, with a clear melody above a soft, even moving accompaniment.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Move between quarters, eighths and triplets without changing pulse.
- ☐ Place unequal divisions accurately within one shared beat.
- ☐ Hear the beat even when an accompaniment enters off it.
- ☐ Keep three subdivisions inside each dotted-quarter pulse.
- ☐ Distinguish solo rubato from timing that a singer can follow.
- ☐ Keep the large 9/8 pulse through the verse and refrain, with a clear melody above a soft, even moving accompaniment.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
